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TRANSPORTATION



Jeh Aerospace nets \$11M to scale the commercial aircraft supply chain in India



Indian startup Jeh Aerospace founders Vishal Sanghavi and Venkatesh Mudragalla have had a front-row seat to the commercial aircraft sector and its growing production bottleneck.

The two former Tata Group executives spent close to two decades in different positions at the company and worked on projects that included participation from global aerospace companies, including Boeing, Sikorsky, and Lockheed Martin.

Now, armed with \$11 million in Series A funding, the pair are working to ease global supply chain bottlenecks by scaling the production of metallic components for aero engines and aerostructures, which it then sells to U.S.-based Tier 1 suppliers that work with commercial aircraft manufacturers such as Airbus and Boeing.

And they plan to help India become a destination for aerospace component manufacturing in the process.

“At Tatas, we unlocked India’s potential for these large OEMs, Boeing, Airbus, Sikorsky, and GE [General Electric], but we wanted Jeh Aerospace to unlock India’s potential for the large Tier 1 and Tier 2 manufacturers in the supply chain,” said Sanghavi, who is also CEO at Jeh.

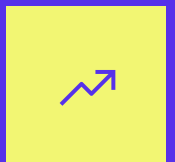
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JEH AEROSPACE CO-FOUNDERS VENKATESH MUDRAGALLA (LEFT) AND VISHAL SANGHAVI (RIGHT).

IMAGE CREDITS: JEH AEROSPACE

[Jeh Aerospace](#), which is headquartered in Atlanta to better access its U.S. customer base, has a 60,000-square-foot software-based, precision manufacturing facility in the southern Indian city of Hyderabad. The 3-year-old startup has combined precision machinery, robotics, and IoT devices to slash product introduction lead times from the industry's traditional 15-week timeline to 15 days.

Jeh Aerospace's software-defined manufacturing approach helps bring predictability and dynamic scheduling to allow offering a consistent supply to customers with no compromises on quality, Sanghavi said.



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And it seems VCs and strategic investors are interested in Jeh Aerospace's pitch.

The Series A round was led by Elevation Capital, with participation from General Catalyst. With the infusion of the new capital, Jeh Aerospace has raised about \$15 million in total from institutional venture capital firms. The VC fresh funding comes less than a month after the startup received an undisclosed strategic investment from IndiGo Ventures, a corporate venture capital arm of Indian carrier IndiGo.

Ashray lyengar, principal at Elevation Capital, said the company "built a truly differentiated approach to aerospace manufacturing."

Aircraft production bottleneck

Global air traffic demand rose 10.4% year-over-year in 2024, surpassing 2019 levels by 3.8%, per the International Air Transport Association data [released](#) earlier this year.

The rebound has spurred airlines to expand fleets, pushing up orders even as the industry grapples with talent and production bottlenecks, as Deloitte [notes](#) in a recent report. Tier 1 suppliers are facing extended lead times as the [commercial aircraft backlog reaches a record of nearly 15,700 units](#), according to McKinsey.

Jeh Aerospace's founders believe using technology to scale production of metallic components for aero

engines and aerostructures will unplug that bottleneck. That premise has shaped how Sanghavi, the former chief operating officer at Tata Boeing Aerospace, and Mudragalla have built its 100-person workforce, team of advisers, and business model.

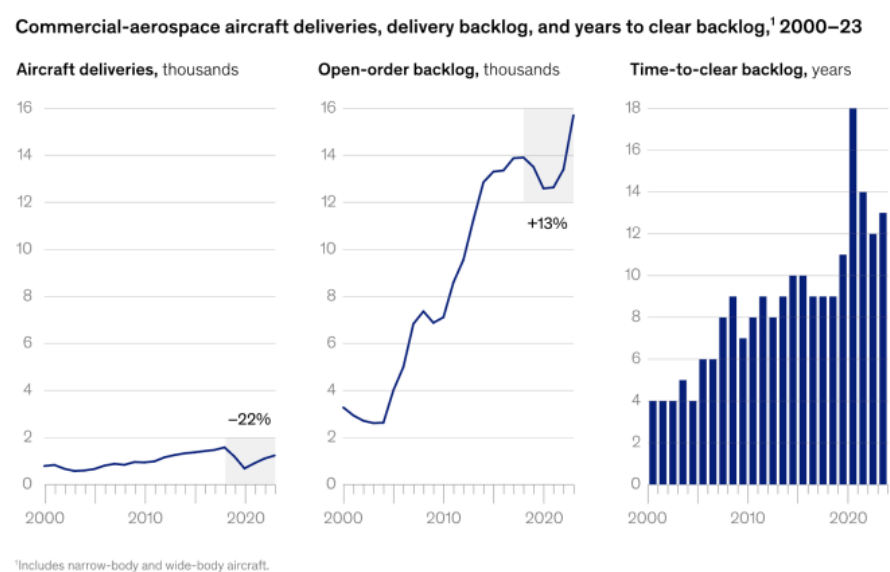


IMAGE CREDITS: MCKINSEY AEROSPACE & DEFENSE PRACTICE

Instead of working directly with OEMs like Airbus and Boeing, which make 30% of commercial aircraft, Jeh Aerospace deliberately decided to tap Tier 1 and Tier 2 manufacturers, Sanghavi told TechCrunch, adding this group makes 60% to 70% of aircraft.

The startup currently has half a dozen paying customers, including Vermont-based GS Precision and Ohio-headquartered RH Aero. Sanghavi said each of these customers is a “high dollar, high ARR customer,” and they have the potential to become large accounts in the next one to two years.

“What we believe is that to work with lesser, but better customers, not to have a transactional relationship, but a far deeper and meaningful relationship. So, we are also very, very focused on not having too many customers,” he said. “The business doesn’t need too many customers because you can really scale with few customers very fast and very quickly.”

The company has also assembled an advisory team with deep ties to commercial aircraft OEMS. The startup counts former Boeing India president Pratyush (Prat) Kumar and former Airbus India CEO and managing director Dwaraka Srinivasan among its early advisers and backers.

Jeh Aerospace has made notable manufacturing and financial progress in its short life.

Since its \$2.75 million seed round in January last year, Jeh Aerospace says it has delivered more than 100,000 flight-critical components and tools on time. The startup has also established a machine capacity exceeding 250,000 hours annually.

In the last financial year, the startup reached \$6 million in annualized recurring revenue (ARR) and achieved profitability after taxes. Sanghavi told TechCrunch that it projects a 3x to 4x increase in its ARR this year and also boasts an order book worth \$100 million.



JEH AEROSPACE'S FACILITY INCLUDES A CENTER OF AEROSPACE SKILL FOR TALENT TRAINING.

IMAGE CREDITS: JEH AEROSPACE

The company plans to use the new \$11 million in capital to scale its manufacturing and inspection capabilities by investing in next-generation digital production technologies, Sanghavi said.

The Jeh Aerospace co-founders see an opportunity to bring more local manufacturing to India and strengthen the country's position on the global aerospace map, much like its recent [emergence as a hub for iPhone production](#).

India already plays a growing role in aerospace manufacturing, with Airbus [sourcing \\$1.4 billion](#) worth of components annually from the country and targeting \$2 billion by 2030. Boeing, for its part, is [aiming for a \\$1.3 billion annual spend](#) and announced its plans to [invest \\$200 million](#) in a new engineering and technology center in Bengaluru in 2023. Still, the South Asian nation has yet to achieve large-scale success in aerospace component manufacturing — a gap companies like Jeh Aerospace are hoping to fill.

Although few Indian startups operate in aerospace component manufacturing, the sector includes players like JJG Aero, which appears to be a peer to Jeh Aerospace based on industry positioning. Sanghavi declined to comment specifically on JJG and noted that his startup sees its primary competition among U.S.-based tier-2 suppliers.

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Starburst Ventures closes \$200 million debut fund to back space tech startups

Lora Kolodny — 5:06 AM PST · November 29, 2016

A new venture fund called [Starburst Ventures](#) has raised a \$200 million debut fund to invest in early stage aerospace startups over the next three years.

The fund is an extension of the Starburst Accelerator, which was founded in 2012 to help aviation and aerospace tech startups raise seed funding, and score their first big deal with a corporate customer, typically representing \$1 million or more in revenue.

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Starburst Accelerator CEO and founder [Francois Choppard](#) told TechCrunch the new fund will aim to back about 35 startups over three years. It will typically write checks of \$3 million to \$5 million for Series A stage deals, reserving capital for larger follow on rounds as well.

Space technology is today where biotech was about 15 years ago, in terms of potential for startups to flourish, Chopard said.

More entrepreneurs and engineers are becoming interested in aerospace and aviation

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Alumni of Starburst Accelerator include companies working on a range of technologies from entertainment and communication systems that could work in flight on a space shuttle, to earth image gathering and analysis systems, and 3-D printing materials and hardware that could allow astronauts to manufacture anything they need to function on a mission.

The accelerator's alumni include [AirMap](#), the maker of a massive, air traffic control system for lower airspace, [Ursa](#) which uses nanosatellites to conduct earth observation and analysis of infrastructure, and developers of autonomous cargo and possibly passenger-carrying drones, [Natilus](#).

Starburst Ventures' first fund counts Leonie Hill Capital in Singapore as its anchor partner. With the family fund's involvement, one of Leonie Hill Capital's partners will become a member of the investment team for Starburst Ventures in its Singapore branch, Chopard said.

Starburst Ventures headquarters office will be in San Francisco, but the firm and accelerator will continue to conduct accelerator and investing activities in Paris, Munich and Singapore, and other cities worldwide.

Chopard expects a preponderance of startups that his new fund will back will come from regions that have led the field aerospace over the last decade, including primarily the U.S., Germany, France, Russia and the U.K.

But he said the best place to build an aerospace startup today is in the U.S. "It used to be that other countries were ahead in terms of regulation, but no longer," he explained. "And the largest market opportunity remains in the U.S."

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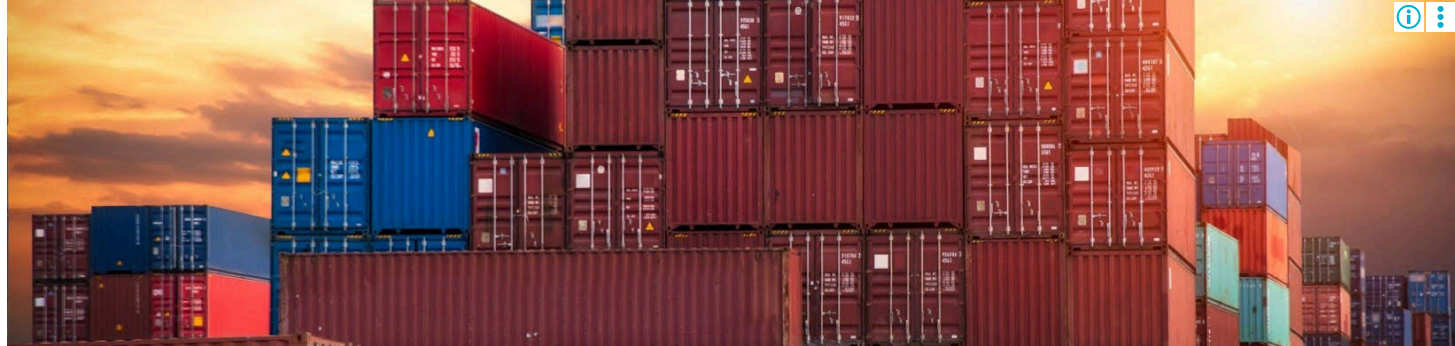
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Supersonic aircraft startup Hermeus raises \$16 million Series A

Hermeus, a company seeking to build a Mach 5 aircraft that would be capable of making the trip from New York to London in just 90 minutes has raised a \$16 million Series A round, led by Canaan Partners and including contributions from existing investors Khosla Ventures, Bling Capital and the Rise of the Rest Seed Fund. The new funding will help the startup develop and ground test its first full-scale engine, the core component that will eventually power its debut Mach 5 aircraft.

Earlier this year, Hermeus was able to successfully demonstrate a subscale engine prototype, showing that the core design of its technology performed as intended. The company now plans to turn that into a version of the engine that matches its eventual production scale and power, while simultaneously expanding the footprint of its Atlanta-based test facility to also include some light in-house manufacturing capability. It's also going to be working to continue the design of its debut aircraft, and says it will be sharing more info about that first plane over the course of the next few months.

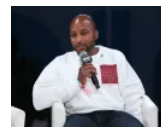
Hermeus says that its target of Mach 5 flight is actually attainable using relatively mature technology already on market, and it cites a team with ample experience across a range of top-flight aerospace companies including SpaceX, Blue Origin, NASA, Boeing and more as another competitive advantage.

IMAGE CREDIT: HERMEUS

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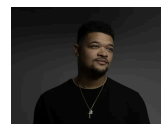
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Mach 5 is nonetheless ambitious, however. The Concorde flew at speeds of just over Mach 2, and startup Boom Aerospace is targeting Mach 2.2 for its Overture commercial supersonic aircraft. NASA's X-59 experimental supersonic jet, built by Lockheed Martin, will cruise at a speed of around Mach 1.42. Mach 5 obviously would be quite a bit faster than even the most ambitious of those projects, but Hermeus CEO AJ Piplica has said previously the company expects it to take around a decade of development before they produce a commercial passenger aircraft.

[Here's your first look at Boom Supersonic's faster-than-sound XB-1 demonstrator aircraft](#)

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